

FASHION ICON

ELIZABETH I

Daughter of Anne Boleyn and Henry VIII, Elizabeth I ruled England between 1558 and 1603. She inherited many of her father's characteristics, including clever use of image and clothing to cement power and excite the adoration of her people. Her wardrobe was legendary, recorded in portraits that publicized the Protestant queen's self-made mythology. Some of her gowns even went on display in the Tower of London during her lifetime to impress foreign visitors. Her shrewdness, intelligence, and ruthlessness made her a political force, just as the magnificence of huge ruffs trimmed with devastatingly expensive handmade lace, enormous embroidered sleeves, and large, structured, bejewelled stomachers turned her into a glittering fashion icon who loved to be admired.

The language of dress

Elizabeth emphasized her tall, slender frame – and her status – with regal headdresses. French hoods and jewelled caps were the perfect foil to set off her flaming red hair. An iconic hairstyle saw her curls twisted over supports to frame her face like a heart with two large puffs on either side. Haloes of pearls and gold outlined the edges of the hairstyle.

Symbolism made Elizabeth's dress and accessories even more compelling. Pearls – worn as long ropes, seed pearls, and pendant drops – were a favourite. As a symbol of purity and chastity they were most appropriate for this Virgin Queen who put her nation before personal happiness. She wears them in almost every portrait from the age of 13, when she was painted wearing sumptuous red silk damask and furs. Her love of fashion, ornament, luxury velvets, damasks, and brocades as well as her use of striking colours finally found expression when she became queen



at 25. Elizabeth favoured red, gold, and silver to complement her pure white complexion and ruddy hair colour. She adopted black and white as her personal colours – a dramatic background for her jewellery and long, elegant fingers. A poet described her as coming in “like starlight, thick with jewels”. Other symbolic items included a phoenix pendant – the fabled bird that rose from the ashes and spoke of the Queen's uniqueness, power, and chastity.

If her dress sometimes appeared overwhelmingly magnificent to foreign tastes, from the 1560s Elizabeth's dominant personality, expressed through clothing, breathed new life into fashion – it was much more staid and darker before her reign. She encouraged her courtiers to dress splendidly – especially the men, who could win her favours with an elegant leg, beautiful clothes, and flattering gifts of gloves, gauzy scarves, and rare jewels.

With such a monarch, 16th-century English people embraced lavish fashions. Although none of Elizabeth's clothing survives, account books unfold luscious descriptions of the queen of fashion's staggering wardrobe.

A royal legacy

Elizabeth's self-fashioning was so successful that she remains an icon in modern times. Her image has been developed in films and television series and inspired designers. The tight bodices, bold shapes, huge ruffs, and regal aura have fed into the work of fashion designers as diverse as Jean Paul Gaultier, Martin Margiela, and Vivienne Westwood. For example, Westwood has showcased slashed fabric, large, regal gowns, ruffs, and enormous collars, while many generally “futurist” fashions feature arrestingly angular shapes reminiscent of Elizabethan style.



△ THE RAINBOW PORTRAIT c.1600

In this late portrait in masque costume, Elizabeth wears a fantastic headdress inspired by an engraving of Greek women's dress. The eyes and ears painted on her mantle and the jewelled serpent on her sleeve may symbolize fame and wisdom respectively. She holds a rainbow, seen in many of her clothes, perhaps suggesting heavenly ideals.

◁ DRESS BY ALEXANDER McQUEEN

The enduring influence of Elizabeth I is clear in this McQueen dress. It features a high neck ruff and sleeves with the built-up shoulder and narrow, trimmed cuff reminiscent of Elizabethan gowns.

TIMELINE

1533 Born at Greenwich, near London

1536 Her mother, Anne Boleyn, is executed. Elizabeth is declared illegitimate. A later Act of Parliament restores her right to succeed to the throne

1558 ▽ Becomes queen. Her coronation robes of 1559 were of cloth-of-gold (fabric woven with gold-wrapped thread) trimmed with ermine, with a tight, pointed bodice



1559 Becomes head of the Church of England, replacing her sister Mary's Catholicism with the Protestant faith

1560s Taking a lead from Elizabeth's delight in clothes, English fashions become more decorated and full of novelty

1580s Inspires English trends for extravagant, exaggerated dress

1581 Knights Francis Drake on his return from a world voyage. Trade links foster the fashion for exotic fabrics and ornament

c.1595 ▽ Embraces all the new fashions, like larger ruffs seen in this gold pound coin



1603 Dies at Richmond, near London

○ 1530

○ 1550

○ 1570

○ 1590

○ 1610

◁ **THE PELICAN PORTRAIT c.1575** Attributed to Nicholas Hilliard, this painting shows the queen wearing a pelican pendant. The pelican was thought to feed her young with her own blood, representing Elizabeth's role as mother of her people.